
THE MEDIE WORLD

500–1492

Historians call the period from 500 to 1500 “the Middle Ages,” seeing it as a separate era sandwiched between the ancient world and modern times. In reality, there was never a clear break with the ancient world. In the eastern Mediterranean, the Roman Empire continued for almost 1,000 years after the fall of Rome, although it was rebranded by historians as the Byzantine Empire. The ancient tradition of a united China ruled by an emperor was revived in the 6th century and continued to the Ming dynasty, albeit with interruptions. Even in Western Europe, where the breakdown after the Roman Empire’s collapse was most evident, Christian religion survived in Rome as the key marker for the distinction between what were considered “civilized” and “barbarian” societies.

The rise of Islam

The dominance of two mutually hostile monotheistic religions—Christianity and Islam—was the most distinctive characteristic of this period across much of Eurasia. The founding of Islam in the 7th century was a transformative event, and Arab armies inspired by the faith

altered the political landscape: Muslim rule spread from Spain in the west to central Asia in the east.

Although a united Islamic caliphate could not be sustained, the religion ensured a continuity of civilization even when power shifted from the Arabs to other peoples such as the Turks. The great cities of the Muslim world surpassed any in Christendom in size and sophistication, and Muslim scholars preserved the science of the ancient Greeks and built upon it. Islamic civilization remained dynamic and expansive throughout the entire medieval period.

Western European fortunes

In Western Europe, civilization fell drastically from the level achieved under the Roman Empire. Warrior kings ruled over a thinly spread population sustained by subsistence agriculture, and the area remained prey to non-Christian raiders and invaders, such as the Vikings and the Magyars, into the 10th century.

A nostalgia for ancient Rome led to King Charlemagne being crowned emperor in 800, but the Holy Roman Empire, based on the tradition Charlemagne founded, failed to unify Western Europe politically. In the